

LINTEL NY · LONG ISLAND EDITION

Long Island vs NYC Renovation Guide

Permit differences by town, cost comparisons, and why most NYC contractors won't come to Nassau or Suffolk.

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Why This Guide Exists

Long Island homeowners have been calling NYC contractors for years and hearing the same answer: 'We don't come out there.' Or they call and get an inflated quote with a travel surcharge baked in. Or they hire a local contractor who operates without the documentation standards they'd expect from a licensed NYC firm.

Lintel NY holds active registration in Nassau County (OCA) and Suffolk County (DLCA) in addition to the NYC HIC license — the only contractor we know of operating at full licensing capacity across all three jurisdictions. This guide explains exactly how Long Island renovation differs from NYC and what to expect.

01 — The Permit System: NYC vs Long Island

This is the most important difference. NYC has one centralized Department of Buildings covering all five boroughs. Long Island does not. Each town has its own building department, fee schedule, permit application forms, and inspection procedures.

	NYC (5 Boroughs)	Nassau County	Suffolk County
Issuing Authority	NYC DOB (centralized)	Each Town Building Dept.	Each Town Building Dept.
Most Common Permit Type	ALT2 (DOB online)	Building + Trade permits	Building + Trade permits
Electrical Wiring Standard	EMT metallic conduit required inside walls	Romex / NM-B permitted	Romex / NM-B permitted
Plumbing License	NYC Licensed Master Plumber	NYS Licensed Plumber	NYS Licensed Plumber
Completion Document	Certificate of Occupancy (CO)	Certificate of Completion	Certificate of Completion
Typical Permit Timeline	5–15 business days (ALT2)	3–10 business days	3–10 business days
Online Filing	Yes (DOB NOW)	Varies by town	Varies by town

02 — Town-by-Town Permit Guide (Nassau County)

Town of Hempstead

Covers: Garden City, Westbury, Rockville Centre, Valley Stream, Merrick, Wantagh, Lynbrook, Oceanside

Largest town in Nassau. Separate building permit + electrical permit + plumbing permit required. All filed with Town of Hempstead Building Department. Inspections scheduled separately per trade. Permit fees calculated on project value. Online portal available for some filings.

Town of Oyster Bay

Covers: Syosset, Bethpage, Plainview, Hicksville, Massapequa, Farmingdale, Old Bethpage

Files through Town of Oyster Bay Building Department. Separate trade permits required for electrical and plumbing. Certificate of Completion issued after all trade inspections pass. Some scopes require a survey before permit can be issued.

Town of North Hempstead

Covers: Great Neck, Manhasset, Port Washington, New Hyde Park, Roslyn

Smaller town, more responsive building department in our experience. Building + trade permits required. Certificate of Completion issued after final inspection. Older homes in Great Neck and Manhasset often have asbestos considerations — EPA RRP protocols required.

City of Long Beach

Covers: Long Beach (independent city, not a town)

Has its own city building department separate from Nassau County towns. All permits filed with Long Beach Building Department. Flood zone considerations affect many properties — check FEMA flood maps before scoping.

03 — Town-by-Town Permit Guide (Suffolk County)

Town of Huntington

Covers: Huntington, Commack, Northport, Cold Spring Harbor, East Northport

Files with Town of Huntington Building Department. Building permit required for all structural, plumbing, and electrical work. Separate trade permits for each licensed trade. Inspections through Building Department. Older homes (pre-1978) in Cold Spring Harbor and Northport require EPA RRP compliance.

Town of Babylon

Covers: Babylon Village, West Babylon, Lindenhurst, Amityville, North Babylon

Town of Babylon Building Department handles all permits. Straightforward permit process. Separate electrical permit filed with Town Electrical Inspector. Certificate of Occupancy required for any change in use or structural additions.

Town of Smithtown

Covers: Smithtown, Kings Park, Hauppauge, St. James, Nesconset

Town of Smithtown Building Department. Strong enforcement of permit requirements. Plumbing permits filed separately with Licensed Plumbing Inspector. Known for thorough final inspections.

Town of Islip

Covers: Bay Shore, Brentwood, Central Islip, East Islip, West Islip, Ronkonkoma

Town of Islip Building Division. Building permit + trade permits required. Some flood zone areas near the bay require elevation certificates — check before scoping any exterior work.

04 — Cost Comparison: Long Island vs NYC

Service	Brooklyn (Baseline)	Manhattan (+15%)	Nassau County	Suffolk County
Bathroom — Full Gut Standard	\$16–38K	\$21–44K	\$18–38K	\$17–36K
Bathroom — Mid-Range	\$35–60K	\$40–69K	\$32–57K	\$30–54K
Kitchen — Mid-Range	\$48–105K	\$55–121K	\$48–108K	\$45–100K
Full Home Renovation	\$180–350K	\$207–403K	\$165–300K	\$155–280K
Panel Upgrade (200A)	\$4–8.5K	\$4.5–10K	\$3.5–7.5K	\$3.5–7K

Why Long Island Can Be Less Expensive

Electrical work is cheaper on Long Island because NYC requires EMT metallic conduit inside walls — a significant labor cost not required in Nassau or Suffolk, where Romex cable is standard and permitted. Co-op board soft costs don't apply (most Long Island properties are single-family or condo). Overall contractor overhead may be lower due to different insurance and regulatory burden.

Why Long Island Can Be More Expensive

Older housing stock (pre-1978) is more common on Long Island than in newer NYC construction, meaning more hidden conditions — knob-and-tube wiring, galvanized plumbing, asbestos-containing materials. Discovery of these conditions during renovation adds scope and cost. We budget a 12–18% contingency on Long Island gut renovations for this reason.

05 — Why Most NYC Contractors Won't Come to Long Island

The honest reason is licensing. Operating legally in Nassau County requires registration with the Nassau County Office of Consumer Affairs (OCA). Suffolk County requires a separate registration with the Suffolk County Department of Labor, Licensing and Consumer Affairs (DLCA). Most NYC contractors have only the NYC HIC license and are not registered in either county. Working without these registrations is illegal and leaves the homeowner without recourse if something goes wrong.

Lintel NY holds all three registrations simultaneously — NYC HIC #2109847-DCA, Nassau OCA, and Suffolk DLCA. This is the structural reason we can credibly serve both markets where most contractors must choose one.

About Lintel NY

Licensed NYC Home Improvement Contractor (HIC #2109847-DCA) · Nassau County OCA Registered · Suffolk County DLCA Licensed · EPA Lead-Safe Certified Firm. Serving Brooklyn, Manhattan, Queens, Nassau County, and Suffolk County. Free on-site consultation. Written estimate within 48 hours. Contact: (212) 347-2111 · info@lintelny.com · lintelny.com